

STORKS

Most species in this group are wetland birds with long legs for walking through marshy or grassy habitats. They snatch prey with their long bill.

Storks, order Ciconiiformes, are tall, upright birds, most often found in open spaces. While some are heron-like waterside species, others forage on dry ground. They have a long-striding walk but can perch on open branches and many nest in trees. Their varied diet includes fish, amphibians, small reptiles and mammals, and large insects. In Africa, storks feed on small animals fleeing grassland fires, and exploit swarms of locusts and grasshoppers.

Storks have a strong and more or less pointed bill. The marabou uses its heavy, powerful bill for everything from displacing vultures at carcasses

of dead mammals to scavenging at refuse tips. Other storks have slimmer bills, some more or less tapered to an upswept or downcurved tip.

All storks have broad wings with “fingered” tips. They soar on rising thermals of warm air to gain height before gliding off over great distances to a new feeding area or on long migratory journeys. Large flocks of white storks cross the Mediterranean Sea at its narrower points, in the same way as migratory birds of prey.

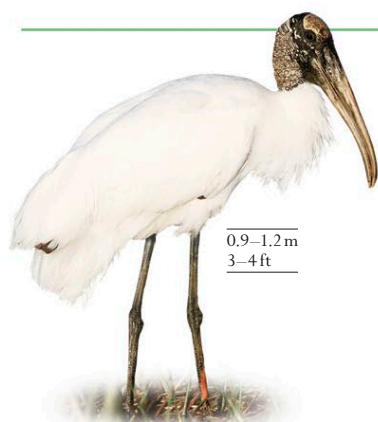
COLONIAL NESTING

Many birds of this group are gregarious when breeding, and their nesting colonies may include several species. All species produce helpless young that must be reared in the nest for some weeks.

CLASS	CHORDATA
AVES	AVES
ORDER	CICONIIFORMES
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	19



Storks typically nest in trees, but in western Europe white storks make good use of level platforms high on buildings.



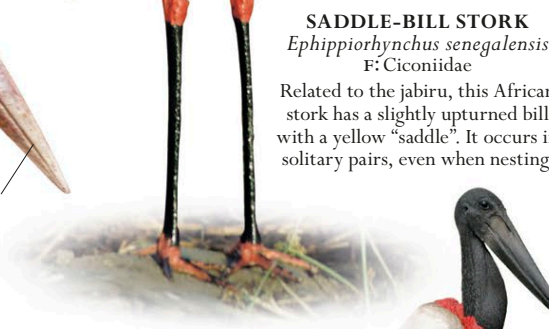
WOOD STORK
Mycteria americana
F: Ciconiidae

This N. American bird belongs to a group of storks with ibis-like bills. It submerges its open bill in shallow water, snapping it shut on moving prey.



EUROPEAN WHITE STORK
Ciconia ciconia
F: Ciconiidae

Three *Ciconia* species breed outside the tropics. This European bird uses thermal updraughts on migration routes over land to winter in Africa.



SADDLE-BILL STORK
Ephippiorhynchus senegalensis
F: Ciconiidae

Related to the jabiru, this African stork has a slightly upturned bill with a yellow “saddle”. It occurs in solitary pairs, even when nesting.



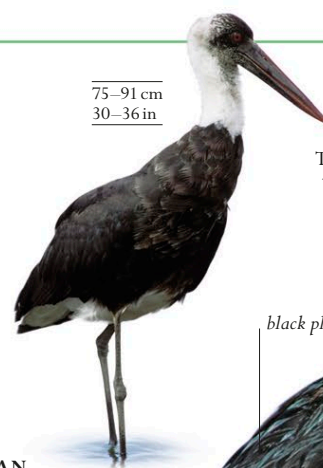
MARABOU
Leptoptilos crumeniferus
F: Ciconiidae

Like other *Leptoptilos* storks, this African species is barcheaded, which enables it to scavenge in carrion without soiling its feathers. It flies with its head retracted.



JABIRU
Jabiru mycteria
F: Ciconiidae

A large American stork, the jabiru is the tallest flying bird in S. America. It expands its featherless neck sac when excited.



WOOLLY-NECKED STORK
Ciconia episcopus
F: Ciconiidae

The most widespread tropical stork, this bird occurs in both Africa and Asia. It prefers wetland habitats but may stray into pasture.



AFRICAN OPENBILL
Anastomus lamelligerus
F: Ciconiidae

Small, tropical wetland storks, openbills use their distinctive bill to catch and manipulate molluscs before eating them. This species occurs in mainland Africa and Madagascar.